

75.6 "FEW" FOR SMALL NUMBERS

"Few" is used with plural countable nouns to say that there are not many of something. It emphasizes how small the number is.

few = not many

There are **few** rare birds here.
We probably won't see any.

"A few" is used with plural countable nouns to mean "some." It emphasizes that the number, though small, is enough.

a few = some

There are **a few** rare birds here.
We might see one.

FURTHER EXAMPLES

"Few" can also be used as a pronoun to mean "not many."

Few are willing to contribute to the upkeep of the national park.



"Very" can be used to stress that the number of something is even smaller.

I wanted to see an owl, but **very few** can be seen during the day.



75.7 "QUITE A FEW" AND "QUITE A BIT (OF)" FOR BIG QUANTITIES

The phrases "quite a bit of" and "quite a few" are understatements that actually mean "a lot" or "many."

quite a few = many

The park is home to **quite a few** species.



quite a bit of = a lot of

There is **quite a bit of** open space for the animals.



FURTHER EXAMPLES

Quite a few of the students in my class don't like History.



There are **quite a few** books that I'd like to read.



There's still **quite a bit of** snow on the ground.



She ate **quite a bit of** cake at her birthday party.

